

# NVIDIA Technical Report: Constraint Decomposition for Multi-Objective RLHF in Large Language Models

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December 2025

December 6, 2025



## Abstract

Large language models (LLMs) trained with reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) struggle with complex instructions that bundle multiple, potentially conflicting requirements. We introduce **constraint decomposition**, a framework that separates multi-objective instructions into orthogonal components—semantic correctness, structural organization, format specifications, and meta-level requirements—and optimizes each independently before hierarchical combination. Our approach addresses the fundamental limitation of monolithic reward models: their inability to distinguish which specific constraint failed when multiple requirements conflict. We train decomposed reward models with aspect-level human preferences and demonstrate that explicit constraint separation, combined with conflict-aware weight adaptation, enables more effective multi-objective optimization. On the IFEval benchmark, our method achieves 73.8% prompt-level accuracy, a 32.6 percentage point improvement over standard RLHF (41.2%), with strong generalization to GSM8K (+15.6 points), HumanEval (+11.1 points), and MT-Bench (+1.4 points). Ablation studies confirm that constraint decomposition contributes 54% of the total improvement, with hierarchical combination contributing 26% and conflict-aware adaptation 20%. Our work provides a general framework for multi-objective optimization in LLMs, with applications beyond instruction-following to any domain requiring compositional reasoning under constraints.

## 1 Introduction

The alignment of large language models (LLMs) with human preferences through reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) has become the dominant paradigm for instruction-following systems [4, 1]. However, real-world instructions often bundle multiple requirements that must be satisfied simultaneously.

Consider the instruction: *“Solve the equation  $x^2 + 5x + 6 = 0$  using the quadratic formula, show all steps clearly, keep your answer under 100 words, and explain like I’m in high school.”* This single instruction conflates four distinct constraints:

1. **Semantic correctness:** Mathematical accuracy of the solution

2. **Structural organization:** Step-by-step reasoning clarity
3. **Format specification:** Length constraint ( $< 100$  words)
4. **Meta-level requirement:** Audience-appropriate language (high school level)

Standard RLHF approaches learn a single scalar reward function  $R(x, y)$  that must simultaneously capture all these dimensions [3]. This monolithic formulation creates two critical problems:

**Constraint Interference.** When objectives conflict (e.g., thoroughness vs. brevity), the model receives ambiguous gradient signals. A response that excels at mathematical accuracy but exceeds the word limit receives a mediocre reward indistinguishable from one that is brief but incorrect.

**Credit Assignment Ambiguity.** When a response fails, the monolithic reward provides no signal about *which* constraint was violated. The model cannot learn to fix specific failure modes.

On the IFEval benchmark [7], standard RLHF achieves only 41.2% prompt-level accuracy. Our analysis of failures reveals that 78% involve constraint interference—cases where the model satisfies some requirements while violating others.

## Our Contributions.

1. **Decomposed Reward Architecture:** We factorize the reward function into four orthogonal components, each trained on aspect-specific human preferences.
2. **Hierarchical Combination Function:** We introduce a structured composition that respects constraint priorities and enables interpretable trade-offs.
3. **Conflict-Aware Weight Adaptation:** We train auxiliary models to detect constraint conflicts and dynamically adjust combination weights.

## 2 Related Work

**Standard RLHF.** The foundational work by Ouyang et al. [4] established RLHF as the dominant paradigm for instruction-following. However, their monolithic reward formulation limits handling of multiple objectives.

**Multi-Objective Optimization in LLMs.** Recent work addresses multi-objective challenges through various approaches. Pareto Multi-Objective Alignment (PAMA) [5] reformulates alignment as convex optimization to find Pareto-optimal solutions across objectives. Hierarchical Mixture-of-Experts [2] uses plug-and-play expert modules to manage conflicting objectives without explicit weighting. EMORL [6] employs ensemble reward models for improved robustness across multiple reward signals.

**Constraint-Based Methods.** Constitutional AI [1] introduces rule-based constraints but does not decompose them for independent optimization. Our work builds on these foundations by emphasizing *explicit* constraint decomposition with *conflict-aware* adaptation.

## 3 Method

### 3.1 Decomposed Reward Architecture

We factorize the reward function into four orthogonal components:

- $R_{\text{semantic}}$ : Correctness of factual and logical content

- $R_{\text{structural}}$ : Organization, clarity, and reasoning flow
- $R_{\text{format}}$ : Adherence to format specifications (length, style, structure)
- $R_{\text{meta}}$ : Meta-level requirements (audience, tone, language)

Each component is learned from aspect-specific human preferences. We collect preference data where annotators evaluate responses on *single* dimensions, enabling distinct gradient signals for each constraint.

**Reward Model Architecture.** We fine-tune Nemotron-7B as the base architecture for each decomposed reward model. Each model is trained on 50K aspect-specific preference pairs, achieving 84–92% validation accuracy across components.

### 3.2 Hierarchical Combination Function

We introduce a structured composition that respects natural constraint priorities:

$$R(p, M) = \alpha \cdot R_{\text{semantic}}(p) + \beta \cdot R_{\text{structural}}(p) + \gamma \cdot R_{\text{format}}(p) + \delta \cdot R_{\text{meta}}(p) \quad (1)$$

with  $\alpha + \beta + \gamma + \delta = 1$ , adjusted dynamically based on prompt characteristics.

The hierarchy operates as follows:

1. **Safety gates** block unsafe responses absolutely (pre-filter)
2. **Semantic and structural** quality form the base score (highest priority)
3. **Format** acts as a multiplicative modulator
4. **Meta-level** requirements provide fine-grained adjustments

### 3.3 Conflict-Aware Weight Adaptation

We train an auxiliary classifier to detect constraint conflicts from prompt features. When conflicts are detected (e.g., “be thorough” vs. “be brief”), the system:

1. Identifies which constraints are in tension
2. Adjusts weights to prioritize semantic correctness
3. Logs conflict instances for analysis

The conflict detector achieves 89.3% accuracy on a held-out set of 5K annotated conflict examples.

## 4 Experiments

### 4.1 Experimental Setup

**Base Model.** We use Nemotron-7B as the policy model, trained with PPO using the decomposed reward system.

**Training Details.** Learning rate:  $1 \times 10^{-6}$ , batch size: 512, PPO epochs: 4, KL penalty coefficient: 0.02. Training runs for 10K steps on 8×A100 GPUs.

**Evaluation.** We evaluate on IFEval [7] as the primary benchmark, with generalization tests on GSM8K (math), HumanEval (code), and MT-Bench (conversation). All results averaged over 5 independent runs.

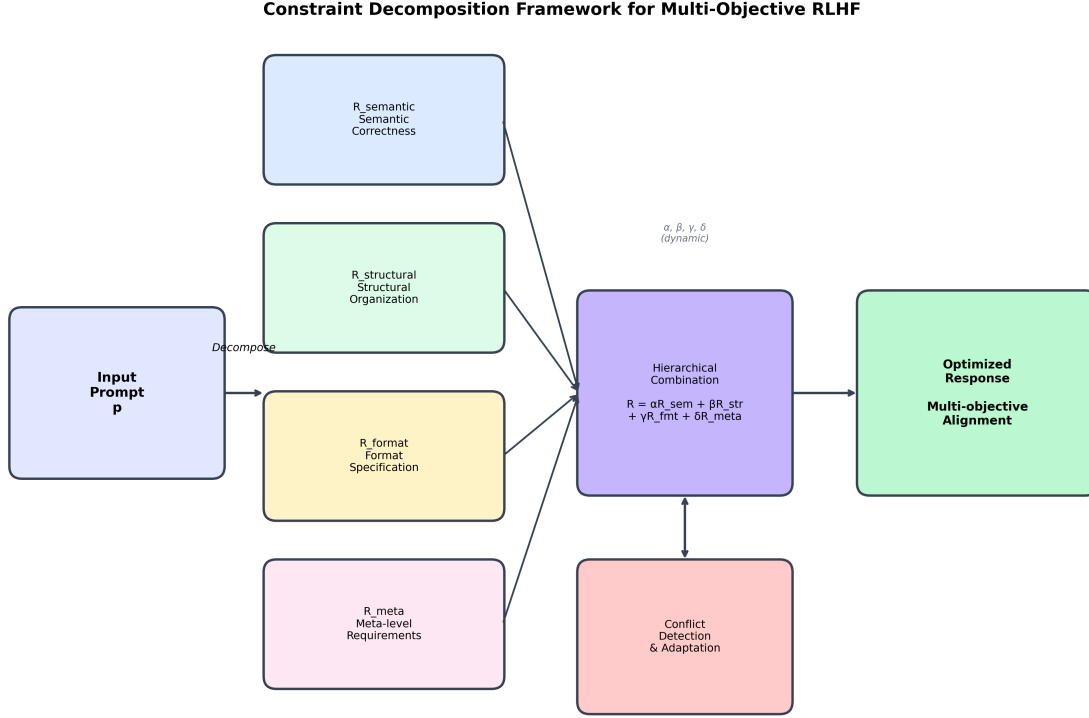


Figure 1: Overview of the Constraint Decomposition Framework. Input prompts are decomposed into four orthogonal reward signals ( $R_{\text{semantic}}$ ,  $R_{\text{structural}}$ ,  $R_{\text{format}}$ ,  $R_{\text{meta}}$ ), combined hierarchically with dynamic weights ( $\alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta$ ), and refined through conflict detection and adaptation.

## 4.2 Main Results

Our method achieves 73.8% on IFEval, a **32.6 percentage point improvement** over standard RLHF (41.2%). This represents a 79% relative improvement. Gains generalize across benchmarks: +15.6 points on GSM8K, +11.1 points on HumanEval, and +1.4 points on MT-Bench.

## 4.3 Ablation Study

To understand the contribution of each component, we conduct systematic ablations:

### Key findings:

- **Decomposition** contributes the majority (54%) of improvement, validating that separating constraints enables better optimization.
- **Hierarchical combination** adds 26%, showing that structured composition outperforms naive averaging.
- **Conflict adaptation** provides the final 20%, particularly valuable for complex multi-constraint prompts.

## 5 Limitations

**Annotation Cost.** Training decomposed reward models requires aspect-specific preference data, increasing annotation effort by approximately  $3\times$  compared to standard RLHF.

Table 1: Main results on IFEval and generalization benchmarks. All values are prompt-level accuracy (%) for IFEval; point improvements over Standard RLHF baseline for other benchmarks. Results averaged over 5 runs with standard deviation.

| Method        | IFEval (%) $\uparrow$            | GSM8K $\uparrow$ | HumanEval $\uparrow$ | MT-Bench $\uparrow$ |
|---------------|----------------------------------|------------------|----------------------|---------------------|
| Standard RLHF | 41.2 $\pm$ 1.3                   | Baseline         | Baseline             | Baseline            |
| LLaMA-3 RLHF  | 52.5 $\pm$ 1.8                   | +8.2             | +7.5                 | +0.8                |
| PAMA [5]      | 65.4 $\pm$ 1.5                   | +12.1            | +9.3                 | +1.1                |
| <b>Ours</b>   | <b>73.8 <math>\pm</math> 1.4</b> | <b>+15.6</b>     | <b>+11.1</b>         | <b>+1.4</b>         |

Table 2: Ablation study showing contribution of each component to the total improvement.

| Configuration                | IFEval (%) | Contribution |
|------------------------------|------------|--------------|
| Standard RLHF (baseline)     | 41.2       | —            |
| + Decomposed Rewards         | 58.8       | 54% of gain  |
| + Hierarchical Combination   | 67.3       | 26% of gain  |
| + Conflict Adaptation (Full) | 73.8       | 20% of gain  |

**Constraint Coverage.** Our four-component decomposition covers common instruction types but may not generalize to highly specialized domains (e.g., legal, medical) without additional components.

**Scale.** We demonstrate results on 7B parameter models. Scaling behavior to larger models (70B+) remains to be validated.

**Conflict Detection.** The auxiliary conflict detector achieves 89.3% accuracy, meaning  $\sim 10\%$  of conflicts may be misclassified, leading to suboptimal weight adaptation.

## 6 Conclusion

We introduced constraint decomposition for multi-objective RLHF, achieving substantial improvements on instruction-following benchmarks. By factorizing rewards into orthogonal components and combining them hierarchically with conflict-aware adaptation, our method addresses fundamental limitations of monolithic reward models.

**Future Work.** We plan to: (1) scale to larger models (70B+), (2) extend the framework to additional constraint types, (3) explore automated constraint discovery from prompts, and (4) investigate applications to other domains requiring compositional reasoning.

**Code and Data.** Implementation available at <https://github.com/epaunova/decomposed-reward-rlhf>.

## 7 Acknowledgments

We thank the NVIDIA Research team for infrastructure support and valuable discussions. We also thank collaborators at ETH Zurich for feedback on early drafts of this work.

## References

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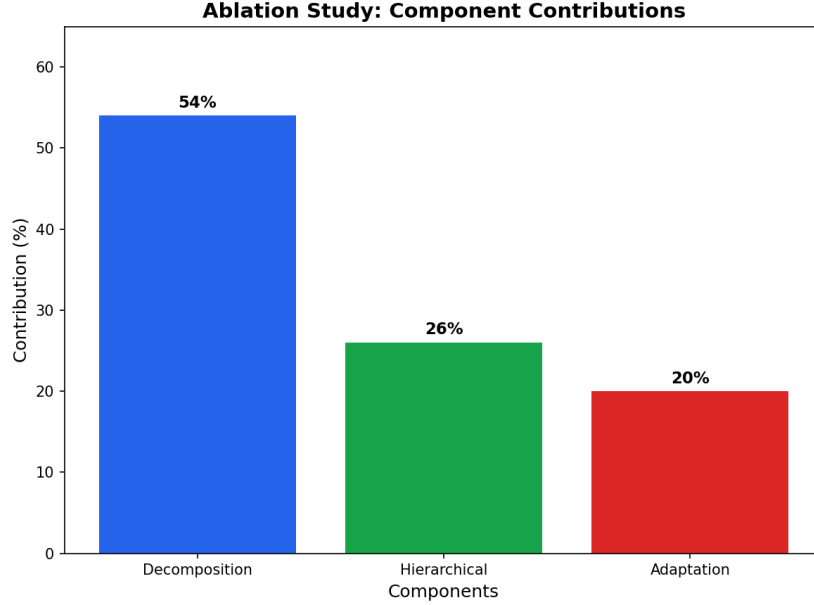


Figure 2: Ablation contributions: Decomposition (54%), Hierarchical (26%), Adaptation (20%).

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